divine flash of light was received by His Majesty' wrote Abu'l Fazl. 'The Divine Call had descended on the Emperor which tranced him completely', agreed Qandahari. 'A strange state and strong frenzy came upon the Emperor,' added Badauni 'and an extraordinary change was manifested in his manner…' Akbar put down his sword and ordered that not a single finch be harmed and thousands of animals were released from the qumargha. From these accounts it would seem that Akbar was overcome by a state of grace, and for a while was even tempted to abandon the affairs of the world. Badauni wrote the following couplet to describe this baffling episode:

> Take care! For the grace of God comes suddenly,
> It comes suddenly, it comes to the minds of the wise

Akbar then sat 'at the foot of a tree that was then in fruit, he distributed much gold to the faqirs and poor, and laid the foundation of a lofty building, and an extensive garden at that place'. He cut off his hair, 'which was long and beautiful and entrancing' and which he had started early in his reign to wear long because of 'an inclination towards the sincerely loyal Indians'. Some of the courtiers present immediately cut off their long hair too. That there was disquiet and bafflement around this ecstatic episode is clear from the fact that, soon after, Hamida Banu Begum arrived at the imperial camp from Fatehpur Sikri. Akbar was delighted and sent Salim and the nobles in advance to greet her and then he rode out himself and 'made the reverence to his visible God (his mother), an act of worship of the true Creator'. The ceaseless vigilance of the harem and of Hamida Banu over the Padshah was made clear by this visit which was unusual enough to be noted by both Abu'l Fazl and Badauni. That Hamida Banu would have been troubled by news of Akbar laying down his arms, and even his authority, was understandable. She knew of her son's steely ambition as well as his restless spirituality. She would have remembered earlier moments of unease, beginning at the age of fifteen. She would have come, perhaps, to remind him of his duty to his people and to his ancestors, and that renunciation was impossible for a Padshah of Hindustan.

In any case, Akbar returned very soon to the task of ruling his empire, enquiring into the land grants made to holy men, and dealing with the various demands on his time. He met with the leading Portuguese merchant from Bengal, one Pietro Tavers, renamed Partab Tar Feringi by Abu'l Fazl, and his wife Leorna who were, we are assured, 'amazed at the laudable